still in the gaol: in 1775, one debtor died of it in May; three debtors and a petty offender in June: three recovered. No infirmary: no bath: no straw: the prisoners lie in their clothes on mats. The men's dungeon swarms with vermin; yet not whitewashed for many years. Of the thirty-one felons, etc., in 1782, fifteen were fines. The Act for preserving the health of prisoners not hung up. In April 1782, one of the prisoners was a woman committed for contempt, with no charge or fine. The warrant runs, "As Royal Power ought not to be wanting to the holy church in its complaints . . . attach . . . till she has made satisfaction to the holy church . . . as well for the contempt . . . as for the injury done unto it."

Thomas Horde, who was confined here for some offence against Government, built the chapel. After his discharge, he had bequeathed £14 a year for a chaplain; and as much to the prisoners. But finding some difficulties would obstruct the execution of that bequest, he altered it, 6 August, 1709, to a legacy of £24 a year, to be distributed among prisoners of both sorts, at £2 a month. For the payment, he bound an estate in Oxfordshire: and to make up any deficiency of that estate, he bound an estate in Berkshire. But this estate having been recovered against the charity since his death, the prisoners have now only thirty-three shillings a month, which was paid by the rector of Lincoln College, and is now paid by the principal of Trinity, who are always two of the twelve trustees. A memorial of the process and result of Mr. Horde's benevolent intention hangs up in the gaol. I have a copy of it; too long to transcribe.

There is another legacy to prisoners of both sorts; 8s. 8d. paid quarterly from Magdalen College. From which also in Lent there is about forty shillings, commonly called forfeit-money. Debtors have in common every Saturday six pounds of mutton; sent by a gentleman of Christchurch College. From two other colleges they have in bread about 2s. a week. Christchurch and New College send them broth; generally three times in a fortnight: the prisoners pay fourpence to the man who brings it.

It is very probable, that the rooms in this castle are the same as the prisoners occupied at the time of the Black Assize. The wards, passages and staircases are close and offensive; so that if crowded, I should not greatly wonder to hear of another fatal assize at Oxford.[1] At my last visit some of the debtors' rooms

[1] Mr. Wisdom (the gaoler) told me that some years ago, wanting to build a little hovel, and digging up stones for the purpose, from the ruins of the court, which was formerly in the castle, he found under them a complete skeleton with light chains on the legs, the links very small. These were, probably, the bones of a malefactor who died in court of the distemper at the Black Assize mentioned page 212.

were whitewashed. The felons' day-room is paved with flat stones, in consequence of their taking up the pebbles for defence, after an attempt to escape. For the same reason their court should be thus paved.

"COUNTY GAOL, OXFORD CASTLE

"A prison is now building for a county gaol and bridewell, on Mr. Blackburn's plan. The very active and worthy magistrate, Mr. Willoughby, has put in practice Dr. Fothergill's favourite scheme of employing the convicts in building, which he had adopted in regard to the intended penitentiary houses.[1] Here the lodges, and the gateway with the chapel over it, will be built entirely by the convicts. These were at work, and guarded only by one man, though several of them, for their good behaviour, had their irons taken off. This proves, that among such delinquents many are reclaimable, and not so entirely abandoned as some are apt to suppose. (They were going to work on the navigation.) The encouragements here given with respect to their diet, clothes, and term of confinement, have been the means of recovering many from their bad habits, and of rendering them useful members of society. Here the convicts are not defrauded of the king's allowance of 2s. 6d. a week."

[From *An Account of Lazarettos*, pp. 170–1.]

WORCESTERSHIRE

COUNTY GAOL, WORCESTER CASTLE

The castle yard is spacious: county members are chosen in it. In the gaoler's house are eleven good lodging-rooms for master's-side debtors; and two small day-rooms; one of which is for common-side debtors: one of these was used, at my former visits, as a chapel; but now there is a larger and more

[1] "Some prisoners, when they are discharged, are completely clothed, have a little money in their pockets, and a good character given them, with a further promise that if they bring at the end of the year, a certificate from the master with whom they work of a good and sober character, they shall be further rewarded."